GAME PITCH · PROPOSAL

Night Trail

A top-down mountain adventure where light is your lifeline

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Game Overview

SYNOPSIS

A lone hiker sets out on a multi-day trek to a high mountain pass. Days are warm and cozy: explore autumn trails, gather supplies and meet fellow hikers at campsites. When the sun sets, the world falls into darkness, and the only safety is the light you carry.

AIM

Create a 2D top-down adventure in Godot 4 where the contrast between cozy days and tense nights creates a distinctive emotional rhythm.

OBJECTIVES

1. Implement a light-as-resource system (headlamp, torches, campfires) using Godot 2D lighting
2. Build a day/night cycle that changes visuals, audio and gameplay
3. Design 3 hand-crafted trail sections: forest, ridge, pass
4. Deliver a playable vertical slice of 20–30 minutes
5. Playtest with at least 5 players and iterate on feedback



Main Mechanic: Light as a Resource

Explore
trails and campsites

→

Gather
wood, batteries, food

→

Sunset
reach camp in time?

→

Survive night
light keeps you safe

→

Dawn
progress and reward

↻ *Repeat each day until you reach the pass*

Day = preparation

Collect firewood, batteries and food. Plan the route to the next campsite before sunset.

Night = spending

The headlamp drains, torches burn out, campfires need fuel. Darkness hides cliffs and wildlife.

The core decision

Push on in the dark to gain ground, or make camp and burn your supplies to stay safe?

Soft failure: lose your light and you wake at the last campsite, minus some items, never your progress.



Game Aesthetic: Day & Night





Day palette: warm autumn

Night palette: blue-black + firelight

Style: top-down pixel art (16×16 / 32×32 tiles). The same forest feels cozy by day and tense by night: lighting does the storytelling.

Game Aesthetic: Assets & Audio







Visual assets

- Tilesets: top-down forest and mountain packs
- Hiker sprite with a 4–8 direction walk cycle
- Soft radial light textures for PointLight2D
- Edits in Aseprite / LibreSprite

Audio

- Day: birdsong, wind, footsteps on leaves
- Night: crickets, distant animals, crackling fire
- Freesound (CC0 / CC-BY), credited in-game

AI images are for the pitch only; shipped assets will all be licensed.

Narrative

PREMISE

The protagonist returns to a mountain trail they once hiked with someone close to them, to finish the route they never completed together.

HOW THE STORY IS TOLD

- Notes left at campsites
- Conversations with other hikers
- Environmental storytelling

Light and optional: rewards explorers, never blocks play.

ACT 1 · THE FOREST

Familiar autumn woods. Notes from an old trip hint at someone who walked here before.

ACT 2 · THE RIDGE

Exposed, colder, longer nights. Other hikers share pieces of the story around the fire.

ACT 3 · THE PASS

The hardest night. Reaching the top completes the route they never finished together.



Requirements: Features

Core gameplay

Player movement
top-down walking, stamina

Light resource system
headlamp, torches, fire fuel

Gathering & inventory
wood, batteries, food

Hazards
cliffs, cold, lost paths

World & atmosphere

Day/night cycle
drives visuals and gameplay

Dynamic 2D lighting
lights, shadows, night tint

3 trail sections
forest, ridge, pass

Wildlife & NPC hikers
AI behaviour, dialogue

Systems & UI

Campsites
save points and rest

HUD
light, warmth, time of day

Menus & settings
brightness, key rebinding

Audio & weather
ambient loops, rain, fog



MoSCoW Prioritisation

MUST HAVE

- Player movement
- Day/night cycle
- 2D lighting & shadows
- Light resource system
- Gathering & inventory
- Campsites (save points)
- 3 trail sections
- HUD
- Main menu & pause

SHOULD HAVE

- Wildlife AI (state machine)
- NPC hikers & dialogue
- Ambient day/night audio
- Narrative notes
- Warmth / cold system

COULD HAVE

- Weather: rain, fog, snow
- Procedural trail generation
- Crafting torches
- Photo mode
- Controller support

WON'T HAVE (this version)

- Multiplayer
- 3D graphics
- Online leaderboards
- Mobile port
- In-game purchases



Technology

Game engine: Godot 4
Open source (MIT, no royalties), built-in 2D lighting, text-based scenes that suit version control and AI-assisted coding.

Lighting	PointLight2D, LightOccluder2D, CanvasModulate
World	TileMapLayer, Y-sorting for depth
AI	finite-state machines, NavigationAgent2D
Effects	GPUParticles2D (fire, rain), fog shaders
Tools	GDScript, Git/GitHub, Aseprite, Claude Code

STATE OF THE ART



Don't Starve (Klei, 2013)
Darkness is lethal; fire is the only safety.



The Long Dark (Hinterland, 2017)
Survival through cold, fire and light management.



A Short Hike (adamgibbs, 2019)
Cozy mountain exploration toward a peak.

Development Methodology: Agile

Product backlog → Sprint planning → 2-week sprint → Playable build → Review & playtest → Retrospective

↻ *Feedback returns to the backlog; 6 sprints in total*

Scrum of One

- Backlog built from the MoSCoW list
- Each sprint ends with a playable build
- Short playtests tune the feel of light and darkness early
- Why not Waterfall: game feel can only be judged by playing, so requirements change

Sprint board (GitHub Projects / Trello)

Backlog	To do	Doing	Done
Wildlife AI	Battery drain	Day/night timer	Movement
NPC hikers	Fire fuel	Player light	Tilemap
Weather			Night tint



Ethical, Legal, Social & Data Security

EXPECTED RATING

PEGI

7

Mildly frightening scenes and sounds at night. No violence, gore, gambling or in-game purchases.

Copyright

Only assets with clear licences (CC0, CC-BY, purchased), full credits screen. AI images used for pitch concepts only.

Ethical

No loot boxes or manipulative design. Soft failure. Accessibility: brightness, colour-blind-safe UI, key rebinding.

Social

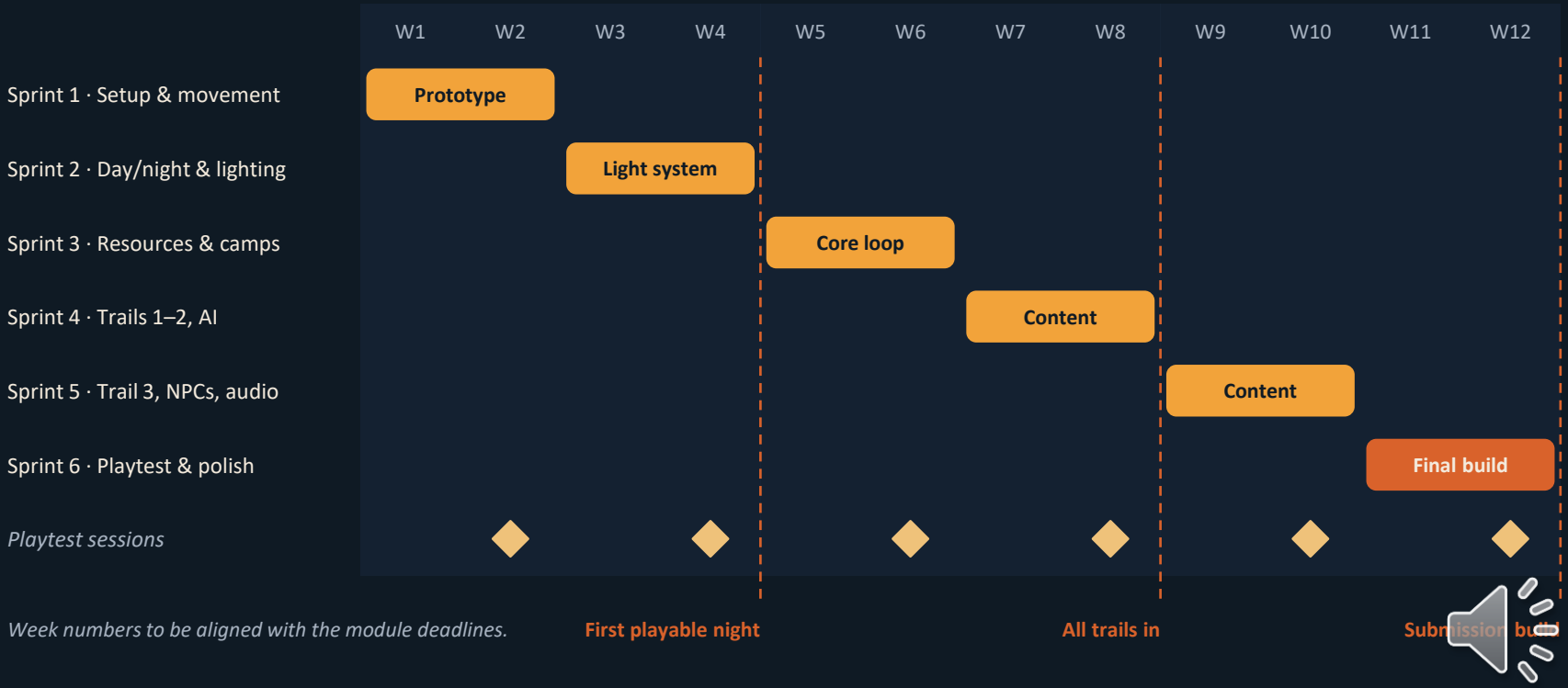
Encourages interest in nature and responsible hiking ('leave no trace' notes). Offline, so no chat to moderate.

Data security

Local save files only: no accounts, analytics or personal data, so UK GDPR risk is minimal. Playtest feedback anonymised.



Forward Plan & Schedule



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